

Pivot away: On U.S. student visas, Trump administration

The **squeeze** on U.S. student visas **is** indicative of **right-wing dominance**

Fresh appointments for U.S. student visa interviews have **commenced** at **consulates** as per the extended **vetting programme** that includes **rigorous** checking of the applicant's social media activities. A **chunk** of visa applications is still pending at a time when the visa processing **winds down** and students prepare to **depart**. Fresh appointments were **frozen** for nearly a month until the extended vetting programme could be launched. With a wait time of more than a month, many visa applications may **go down to the wire** as classes begin by the end of August/beginning of September. The extended vetting is only one among many **disruptors** to the flow of Indian students to the U.S. Many other policy proposals have **had a chilling effect**. The Trump administration's **nominee** to head the U.S. Citizenship and Immigration Services **has vowed** to end the Optional Practical Training programme (OPT) that allows students time to work in the U.S. after graduation while still on student visa, and which serves as a **segue** toward jobs, work visas and green cards. Ending OPT will **disincentivise** studying in America. The Trump administration has also said that it will provide only fixed-tenure student visas. The **axing** of government spending and funding of research and other activities of higher education institutions **has** had its impact — there are reports of universities **rescinding** PhD admissions of Indian students. **Anecdotal** evidence **points to** a sharp decline in visa issuance in several cities and increased **scrutiny** of the ranking of institutions **granting** admissions. **Many** of the applicants this year **had** begun the application process before the 2024 U.S. presidential election and, therefore, have **sought** to go through the process despite the fears. Next year will truly **gauge** how attractive the U.S. still is for Indian students.

When the Trump administration took office, it was felt that the worst of its **anti-immigrant impulses** would be **softened** by the tech billionaires who were supporting it. In the past, too, big business had **driven** policies bringing in talented immigrant workers and foreign students in Republican administrations. The **exit** of Elon Musk, however, **is** not a **singular** event but part of a trend of top **techies** exiting the Trump team. The **cuts** on green energy research in the recently passed "Big Beautiful Bill" only **serve** to **highlight** the almost complete **dominance** of right-wing **extremists** in the administration, **marked** by the extreme views of its **leading lights** such as Stephen Miller, White House Deputy Chief of Staff for Policy. The **decline** of the U.S. as a major attraction for Indian talent **is** **perhaps** only an indicator of how much India may have to pivot away from the U.S. in other areas as well.

[Practice Exercise]

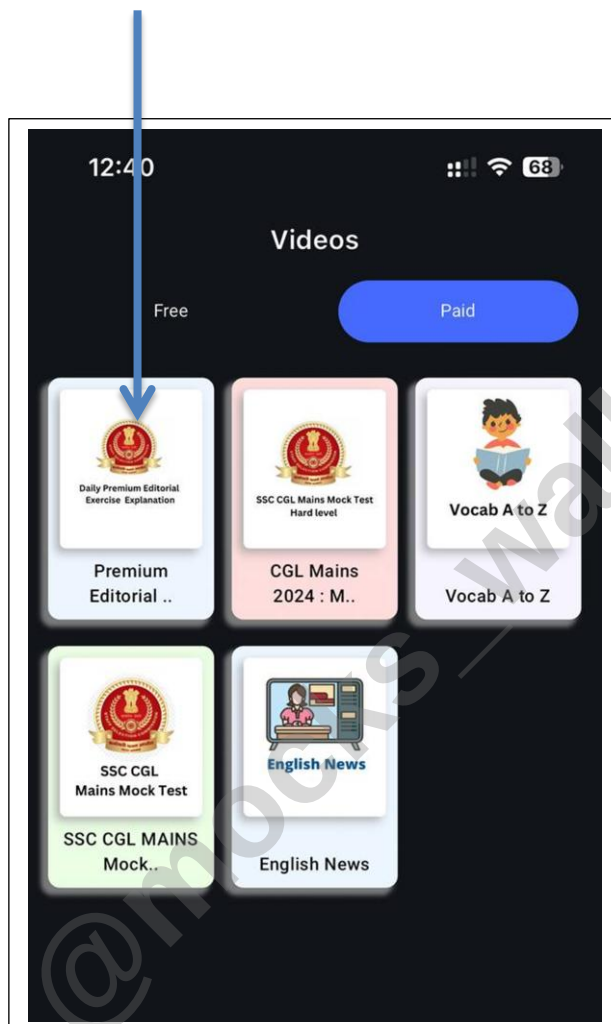
- Red/blue coloring of words in the sentence indicates subject verb relationship; where 'red' denotes 'subject' and 'blue' denotes 'verb'.

Vocabulary

1. **Pivot away** (phrasal verb) – turn away, shift, move away, veer off, divert मुड़ जाना / दूरी बनाना
2. **Squeeze** (noun) – pressure, compression, strain, constriction, tightness दबाव
3. **Right-wing** (adjective) – advocating or taking measures to promote free enterprise and private ownership, and typically favouring socially traditional ideas; conservative. दक्षिणपंथी
4. **Dominance** (noun) – control, supremacy, power, influence, authority प्रभुत्व
5. **Commence** (verb) – begin, start, initiate, launch, inaugurate शुरू करना
6. **Consulate** (noun) – embassy office, diplomatic mission, foreign office, representation, consular post वाणिज्य दूतावास
7. **Vetting programme** (noun) – screening process, verification system, evaluation program, assessment plan, scrutiny process जांच कार्यक्रम
8. **Rigorous** (adjective) – strict, thorough, severe, exacting, meticulous कड़ा / कठोर
9. **Chunk** (noun) – portion, part, segment, slice, section हिस्सा
10. **Wind down** (phrasal verb) – slow down, conclude, finish, wrap up, ease off समाप्त करना / धीमा होना
11. **Depart** (verb) – leave, exit, go, withdraw, vacate प्रस्थान करना
12. **Frozen** (adjective) – halted, stopped, suspended, immobilized, stagnant स्थगित
13. **Go down to the wire** (phrase) – used to denote a situation whose outcome is not decided until the very last minute आखिरी वक्त तक चलना
14. **Disruptor** (noun) – disturber, changer, innovator, interrupter, transformer बाधा डालने वाला
15. **Have a chilling effect** (phrase) – discourage, deter, inhibit, stifle, suppress रोक लगाने वाला प्रभाव डालना
16. **Nominee** (noun) – candidate, appointee, contender, representative, aspirant उम्मीदवार
17. **Vow** (verb) – promise, pledge, swear, affirm, commit कसम खाना
18. **Segue** (noun) – transition, shift, link, connection, progression बदलाव
19. **Disincentivise** (verb) – discourage, deter, demotivate, inhibit, restrain हतोत्साहित करना

20. **Axing** (noun) – cutting, termination, cancellation, abolishment, elimination समाप्ति
21. **Rescind** (verb) – revoke, cancel, annul, withdraw, repeal रद्द करना
22. **Anecdotal** (adjective) – unverified, informal, hearsay-based, casual, illustrative किस्से के आधार पर
23. **Point to** (phrasal verb) – indicate, show, suggest, highlight, reveal संकेत करना
24. **Scrutiny** (noun) – examination, inspection, investigation, analysis, review जांच
25. **Grant** (verb) – give, award, bestow, provide, allow देना / प्रदान करना
26. **Seek** (verb) – look for, search, pursue, request, strive प्रयास करना
27. **Gauge** (noun) – measure, indicator, standard, benchmark, scale मापदंड
28. **Anti-immigrant** (adjective) – xenophobic, nativist, exclusionary, intolerant, anti-foreigner प्रवासी विरोधी
29. **Impulse** (noun) – urge, instinct, drive, compulsion, inclination प्रेरणा
30. **Soften** (verb) – moderate, ease, lessen, mitigate, alleviate नरम करना
31. **Drive** (verb) – push, propel, motivate, lead, encourage प्रेरित करना
32. **Singular** (adjective) – unique, exceptional, extraordinary, remarkable, unusual अद्वितीय
33. **Techy** (noun) – technology expert, geek, technocrat, IT professional, computer whiz तकनीकी विशेषज्ञ
34. **Highlight** (verb) – emphasize, underline, stress, showcase, spotlight ज़ोर देना
35. **Dominance** (noun) – supremacy, control, command, authority, power प्रभुत्व
36. **Extremist** (noun) – radical, fanatic, zealot, militant, hardliner कट्टरपंथी
37. **Mark** (verb) – signify, indicate, characterize, represent, denote चिह्नित करना
38. **Leading light** (noun) – a person who is prominent or influential in a particular field or organization. प्रमुख व्यक्ति
39. **Perhaps** (adverb) – maybe, possibly, conceivably, perchance, potentially शायद

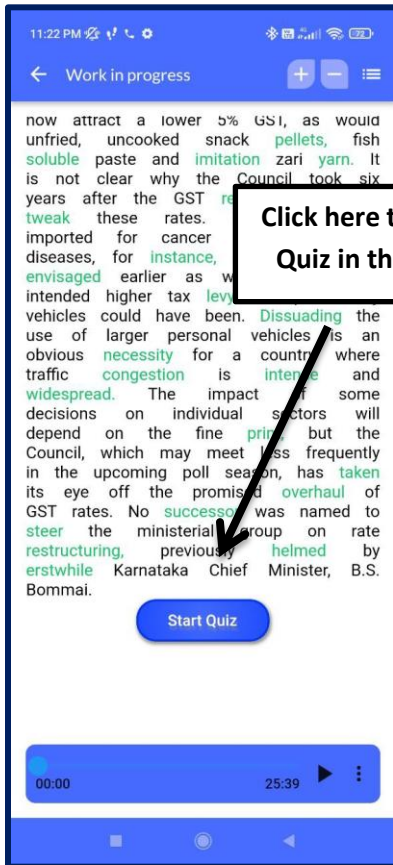
Video solution of Practice Exercise from this Editorial is exclusively available on App.



Summary of the Editorial

1. Fresh U.S. student visa appointments have resumed after a freeze, under an extended vetting programme that checks applicants' social media.
2. Many Indian student visa applications remain pending, with tight deadlines as classes start in late August/early September.
3. The new vetting and appointment delays have caused uncertainty, pushing many applications "down to the wire."
4. This is part of a broader crackdown on immigration under the Trump administration, especially targeting students.
5. A key threat is the plan to end the Optional Practical Training (OPT), which allows students to work in the U.S. post-graduation.
6. Ending OPT would remove a vital career pathway, discouraging students from pursuing U.S. education.
7. The administration also plans to offer fixed-term visas, adding to the uncertainty and limiting flexibility.
8. Funding cuts to U.S. universities have affected research and higher education, leading to rescinded PhD offers to Indian students.
9. There's increased scrutiny on the ranking and credibility of admitting institutions, impacting student visa approvals.
10. Visa issuance has reportedly declined sharply in many Indian cities, based on anecdotal evidence.
11. Many students began applications before the 2024 U.S. election, unaware of the extent of future visa challenges.
12. The situation may worsen in the next cycle, which will truly test the U.S.'s appeal to Indian students.
13. Initially, tech giants were expected to moderate Trump's immigration stance, but that influence has diminished.
14. The exit of Elon Musk and other tech leaders from the Trump camp signals a broader disengagement from the administration.
15. With increasing right-wing dominance, India may need to rethink its educational and strategic dependence on the U.S., signaling a possible pivot away from American institutions.

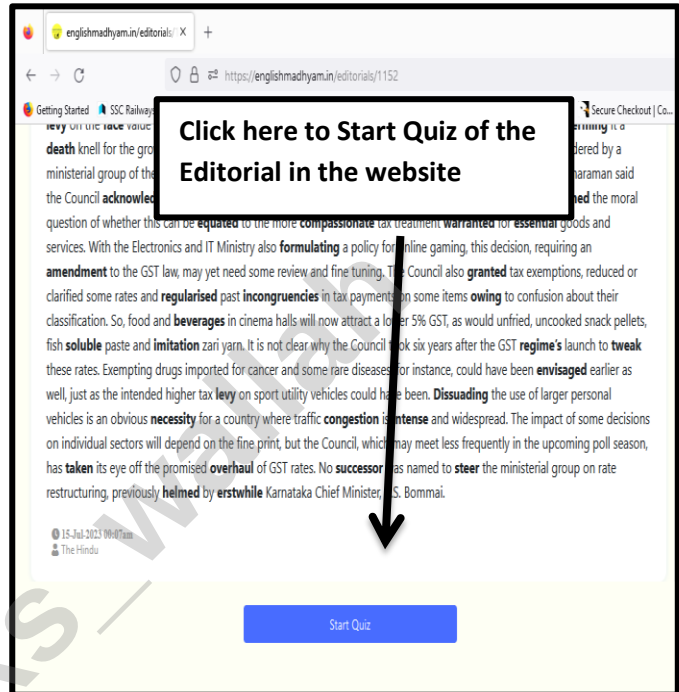
Practice Exercise: SSC Pattern Based



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